Study Abroad CRM: Product Requirements Document

Project brief for an internship project. Team of two developers, 3-4 week timeline.

1. Overview

Purpose. A customer relationship management (CRM) system for a study-abroad consultancy. It replaces spreadsheets, chat threads and paper files with one place to track every prospective student from first inquiry to final admission outcome.

The problem. A consultancy handles many students at once, each with a long, document-heavy journey: inquiry, counseling, shortlisting universities, collecting documents, applying, and waiting for offers. Without a shared system, follow-ups get missed, documents go missing, application deadlines slip, and managers can't see how the business is doing.

The core idea. One clear flow, done well: **Lead, then Student, then Application, then Outcome.**

2. Goals and non-goals

Goals

- No inquiry or follow-up gets forgotten.
- Every student has one complete profile: background, test scores, documents, applications.
- Counselors always know which application deadlines are coming up.
- Managers get a live picture of leads, conversions, applications and office finances.
- Access is controlled: each person sees and does only what their job needs.

Non-goals (this version). A student-facing portal, messaging integrations, student fee payments and commissions, multiple branches, and automated workflows.

3. Users and roles

The system is used internally by one consultancy. Every person has a role, and an admin can adjust access beyond the role.

Role	What they do
Admin / Manager	Sees everything. Manages users, permissions, the university catalog and office accounts. Reviews reports.
Counselor	Works their own leads and students: follow-ups, profiles, documents and applications.
Front desk	Captures new inquiries, assigns them to a counselor, and creates follow-up tasks.

Granular permissions. Each role carries a base set of permissions. An admin can edit a role's permission matrix from the UI, and can also grant or deny individual permissions for a specific person. Permissions can be limited to a person's own records or opened to all records.

4. Features

Module	What it does
Sign-in and access control	Login with email and password, role-based access, password change, and menus and buttons that match each person's permissions.
Leads	Capture inquiries (contact details, source, destination country, intake, test status). Assign to a counselor. Move through the pipeline: New, Contacted, Counseling scheduled, Converted or Lost. Search and filter. Attach documents. Keep an activity timeline of calls, notes and meetings.
Tasks and follow-ups	Create dated tasks linked to a lead. Views for Today, Overdue, Upcoming and All. Quick completion. Shown on the lead page as well.
Students	Created by converting a lead. Profile with personal details, preferred countries and courses, education history and test scores (IELTS, TOEFL, SAT and others).

Module	What it does
Document checklist	A per-student checklist (passport, transcripts, SOP and so on) with status Pending, Received or Verified, remarks, and file upload and download.
University catalog	Admin-managed list of countries, universities, programs and intakes with application deadlines. Everyone can browse it.
Applications	A student can apply to many programs. Pick country, university, program and intake. Track Draft, Submitted, Offer, Accepted or Rejected, with a history of every change and deadline warnings. Filter across all applications.
Dashboard	Leads by status and source, new leads and conversions per month, tasks due and overdue, applications by status, and deadlines in the next 30 days. Counselors see their own figures; admins see the whole office.
Accounts	Admin-only office bookkeeping: rent, salaries, utilities and other income and expenses, with categories and a monthly summary.
Users and permissions	Add and deactivate users, reset passwords, edit the role permission matrix, and set per-person overrides.

5. Key use cases

1. **Capture an inquiry.** A walk-in or online inquiry arrives. The front desk records the lead, picks the destination country and assigns a counselor. A follow-up task is created.
2. **Follow up.** The counselor opens Today's tasks, calls the lead, logs the call on the timeline, and schedules the next follow-up or marks the lead as lost with a reason.
3. **Convert to a student.** After a counseling session the lead agrees to proceed. The counselor converts the lead. A student profile and a document checklist are created, and documents already attached to the lead carry over.
4. **Build the profile.** The counselor records education history and test scores, uploads documents as they arrive, and marks them verified once checked.

5. **Apply to programs.** The counselor shortlists programs through country, university, program and intake, creates applications, and moves each through submission, offer and decision. The deadline shows on every application.
6. **Run the office.** The manager opens the dashboard to see conversions, overdue follow-ups, upcoming deadlines and monthly income and expenses, and records office expenses in Accounts.
7. **Manage access.** The admin adds a new counselor, adjusts what the counselor role may do, and gives one person extra access, such as viewing all leads, without changing their role.

6. Constraints and assumptions

- **Technology:** React front end, Node/Express API, PostgreSQL database; uploaded files stored on local disk or a free object store.
- **One organization:** a single consultancy, a single currency, no multi-branch support.
- **Files:** PDF, JPG, PNG or DOCX, up to 10 MB each.
- **Security:** token-based sign-in; permissions enforced on the server as well as hidden in the UI; admin-only control over roles and overrides.
- **Interface:** web application, usable on desktop and tablet screens.

7. Out of scope and future work

- **Not in this version:** student portal, WhatsApp or SMS integration, student payments and commissions, agent or partner management, multi-branch support, and workflow automation.
- **Possible next steps:** appointment calendar for counseling sessions, email reminders for due follow-ups, CSV export of leads, and a kanban view of the lead pipeline.

8. Success criteria

- A new inquiry can be taken all the way to an accepted application in one system, by each role, without leaving the app.
- Each role sees only the modules and records its permissions allow, and an admin's permission changes take effect.
- The dashboard figures match the underlying lists.

- The system can be demonstrated end to end from sign-in to the dashboard to a supervisor.

9. Status and next steps

- **Built:** the full front end for all modules, working against built-in sample data. Supporting documents exist for the database schema, the API contract, a backend handoff, and the permission design.
- **In progress:** the back end (API and database).
- **Next:** quality testing of the front end, connecting it to the real API module by module, then the demo script, README and final report.